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Why AI Training Is Driving Adoption but Not Sustainable Productivity

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Training drives adoption, but not productivity. Most managers assume these are the same thing, but they are not.

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Train employees, drive adoption, watch productivity rise. It's the logic most organizations have built their AI strategies around. But new data tell a more complicated story. Training drives adoption. But adoption alone does not deliver productivity. There is a gap in the middle, and most leaders are not closing it.

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Last year, our *Bridging the Generational AI Gap* report, a collaboration between The Inclusion Initiative at the London School of Economics and Political Science and Protiviti, surveyed more than 3,000 employees and executives across multiple countries.¹ The study examined how employees across different generations were adopting AI in their day-to-day work, the productivity benefits they reported, and the factors associated with successful use. It also explored participation in AI initiatives, employees’ confidence in AI-driven decisions, and the role of training in shaping adoption.

On the surface, younger employees appeared more likely to adopt AI than their older colleagues. Yet much of that difference coincided with unequal access to training opportunities. We found that 93% of employees who had received AI training were using the tools, regardless of age, compared with 57% of those without training. Among employees using AI for their job, those who received skills training in the past year report saving around 10 hours per week (28% of working time), roughly double the five hours (14%) reported by employees without training. The takeaway seemed clear: despite the common assumption that AI is naturally a young person’s technology, differences in adoption appeared

to be driven more by access to training opportunities than by age itself. Widening access to high-quality AI training could help increase adoption across generations and unlock the productivity benefits that many organizations were hoping to achieve.

We pushed the question further. In a follow-up survey with 859 workers, we asked how employees actually use the time they save. The results show exactly where the link between AI training and productivity holds, and where it fractures.

Training Is an Adoption Lever

Let's start with what training clearly does well. Among employees with no interest in AI training, just 12% are regular AI users. Among self-guided learners who have taken it upon themselves to explore AI tools, occasional use is the norm: engaged but not embedded. The shift comes with company-provided training, after which about half of employees become regular users, and almost no one reports zero use. That's a fourfold increase in regular adoption in company-trained employees compared to those with no interest in AI training.

So training works. The gap between self-guided and company-provided training is not about instructional quality, but about what surrounds the training.

Adoption without integration might initially drag down productivity, as firms experience short-term performance losses before longer-term gains materialize.² Established routines break before new ones form, and the cognitive overhead of learning erodes the very efficiencies AI is supposed to deliver. Company-provided training works because it is bundled with the environment that makes use stick: approved tools, integrated workflows, and colleagues on a similar learning curve. Training can drive AI adoption, but translating that adoption into effective day-to-day AI integration requires an environment that supports it. Neither is likely to reach its full potential without the other. That ecosystem turns a course into a habit.

The Boundary: Training Changes Frequency, Not Time Saved

If training creates regular users, and regular users apply AI daily, surely these regular users must be saving dramatically more time than everyone else? That's the intuitive expectation. But the data doesn't support it.

Across all employees surveyed, the majority reported saving 0 to 3 hours per week. The probability of saving 1-3 hours per week hovered around 50% regardless of the training they received. This held for both occasional and regular users alike. Some saved more, but those higher savings didn't scale predictably with training intensity or usage frequency. Moving from "no interest in training" to "company-provided training" barely shifted the amount of time saved. Firm training is a powerful predictor of **whether** someone uses AI. It is a weak predictor of **how much time** they save by doing so.

One possible explanation for this is that AI is increasingly woven into workplace infrastructure, through meeting transcription, project summary, automated scheduling, and smart search, in ways that save time without people consciously attributing it to "AI use." The modest figures may partly reflect what employees notice and report, not the full picture.

Another possible explanation is the efficiency illusion. Improvements in task-level efficiency do not automatically translate into productivity gains at the system level. While AI may accelerate individual activities, it can also generate additional review, coordination, and decision-making work that consumes attention elsewhere in the workflow, limiting the amount of time ultimately saved.³

Still, the core finding holds. The link between how often someone uses AI and how much time they believe it saves is far weaker than leaders might assume. What company training reliably does is build the behavioural foundation for regular,

embedded use. Its contribution is not time saved but conditions created.

Where Value Actually Appears

If the time-saved numbers are modest, then where does AI's productivity contribution actually show up? In our data, the clearest signal comes not from how much time people save, but from what they choose to do with it.

We gave employees four options for how they were using any time freed by AI: reinvesting in higher-value work, taking on new responsibilities, improving work-life balance, or “not sure yet.” The patterns vary by group but tell a consistent story about reinvestment. Among regular users, reinvestment into higher-value work is high even at low levels of time saved (54% among those saving less than an hour) and reaches 57% among those saving the most. The key difference lies not in the ceiling but in the floor: regular users are more likely to reinvest purposefully, regardless of how much time they save, whereas occasional users need larger savings before reinvestment becomes the dominant pattern.

Employees are not using AI to leave early. When used effectively, AI lets workers widen what they take on, though the biggest gains come only when people balance it against their own common sense rather than leaning on it too heavily.⁴ Our data supports this instinct, with people spending freed-up time doing more rather than less, which carries its own risk of burnout, which we take up below.

At the organizational level, while most firms are not cutting jobs in response to AI gains, the harder question is where the resulting reinvestment lands.⁵ Industry research suggests firms are still directing more of their AI savings into technology and infrastructure than into their own workforce, when the fuller value comes from investment in employee training, role redesign, and human judgement.⁶ Cutting the human middle to save money quickly also removes the people who

catch AI's mistakes, which pushes legal and ethical risk straight up to senior leaders.⁷ Keeping people in place and investing in them is what keeps those checks working.

If reinvesting saved time is where the value sits, the conditions that support it matter just as much. Based on our data, we find that for employees, reinvestment of time saved into higher-value work is most consistent where three conditions align: structured training, regular use, and meaningful time savings. Where any of those conditions is absent, reinvestment becomes less predictable, and uncertainty in productivity benefits grows. These are the conditions that training programs and organizational design can directly shape.

What This Means for Leaders

Measure the full chain, not just the first link. Training completion tells you about logistics. Adoption frequency tells you about behavioral change. But the most informative metric is what happens **downstream** of adoption: are people reinvesting freed capacity into higher-value work, or is it disappearing into busier days? In practice, organizations often find it difficult to measure, as employees are reluctant to explicitly articulate how their work has changed. However, the apparent ease of AI tools can trick leaders into thinking the rest will be just as effortless, when real returns still rest on solid data, careful testing and steady iteration.⁸ Research consistently shows that most AI pilots fail to scale, often because organizations layer tools onto existing processes rather than redesigning work around them.⁹ While anonymous surveys provide some signal, clear and consistent reporting of behavioural change remains rare, leaving room for leaders to consider and act.

Invest in ecosystems, not just courses. The self-guided plateau in our data is not a motivation deficit. It's an infrastructure deficit. Company training works because it comes wrapped in an environment: approved tools, integrated platforms, colleagues learning alongside you, and organizational signals that this

is the expected way of working. AI makes these cultural investments tangible for the first time, but only when organizations define clearly what good AI-enabled work looks like.

One example is being deliberate about how people and AI divide the work. A useful framework here distinguishes four modes of human-AI collaboration, ranging from full automation at one end to humans taking the lead with minimal AI involvement at the other, and argues that the right mode depends on how familiar, complex, and value-laden the problem is.¹⁰ A related argument holds that placing humans at every stage of AI execution can create bottlenecks. The greater value comes when people concentrate on setting direction at the outset, defining goals, constraints, and success criteria, and allow AI to work within them.¹¹ Without that clarity, training produces occasional users who never quite embed.

Watch for new fault lines. AI adoption is creating new pressures around psychological safety. There is “AI shaming,” where employees are, or feel, judged for using AI too much or in the wrong way, and “non-AI shaming,” where slower adopters feel behind or less competent. Together, these dynamics erode psychological safety and highlight the importance of inclusivity in the workplace. With this transition in the way we work occurring so rapidly, managing that fear well becomes important. Pressuring employees to adopt AI indiscriminately therefore risks creating uncertainty rather than value. Unlike many earlier waves of workplace technology, AI does not lend itself to a single set of standard operating procedures. The same tool can be highly effective in one role or task and add little value in another, making it difficult for employees to know what good AI use looks like. That is one reason why role-specific guidance and company-provided training remain important. Successful AI adoption is most likely when leaders clarify purpose, communicate proactively, prepare for AI-related failures before they occur, and position AI as a collaborative partner rather than a replacement.¹²

Design for sustainability, not just speed. As AI gains are achieved, organizations need to step back from AI-assisted work every so often. If not, AI-enabled speed can expand workload and lead to overload or burnout as employees take on broader, more intense roles.¹³ Sustaining performance therefore requires workflows that protect both focused work and opportunities for rest.¹⁴ The line between productive momentum and burnout is thinner than it looks when everything moves faster.

The Chain, and Where It Breaks

Most employees work fixed hours. When AI helps someone finish a task faster, they don't leave early. The remaining time gets filled with something. The question that matters is not how much time AI saves. It is what happens to that time.

As with any major investment, executives look for clear returns. Yet what constitutes a return in practice remains difficult to define across the organization. Training powerfully shifts adoption frequency, but it does not reliably increase how much time employees save. When employees do save meaningful time, whether AI delivers real value comes down to a single question: what happens to that time, and has anyone in the organization thought about it?

Others have documented what goes wrong when AI gains are mismanaged: rework, intensity, burnout. We suggest that 'the reinvestment gap', the space between using AI regularly and knowing what to do with the time it gives you in an organization that supports that choice, is where the next wave of AI value will be.

AI training can get people to use the tools. The harder challenge is ensuring that what people do with the time AI frees delivers productivity that is not just high, but sustainable. That is a human-centered design problem, not a technology procurement one.

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